

IN A YEAR OF BOX-OFFICE FAILURES, ONLY A FEW HINDI FILMS STOOD OUT. THEIR SUCCESS DIDN'T COME FROM A COMMON THEME OR BUDGET SIZE, BUT FROM DIFFERENT STRATEGIC CHOICES, INCLUDING TIMING, STORYTELLING, CASTING, AND COST CONTROL. FROM A SPY THRILLER TO A MUSICAL FEATURING NEWCOMERS, AN ANIMATED MYTH, AND A SPORTS DRAMA, EACH FILM SUCCEEDED ON ITS OWN TERMS, DEMONSTRATING THAT THERE IS NO SINGLE FORMULA FOR SUCCESS IN TODAY'S MARKET.

Two years ago, an opportunity beckoned for the team at Jio Studios. The spy genre had long fascinated audiences, but the films produced had failed to capture interest. “What one had seen was mediocre. The challenge was to make it entertaining,” says Jyoti Deshpande, President, Jio Studios, the media and content business of RIL. That eventually led to *Dhurandhar*, a film that ensured a happy 2025 for Bollywood, in a landscape dominated by flops.

Only four films succeeded (excluding the dubbed versions originating in the south), but each brought a valuable insight that Bollywood would like to apply to its filmmaking process. Together, *Chhaava*, *Saiyaara*, *Sittaare Zameen Par* and *Dhurandhar* grossed nearly ₹2,000 crore at the domestic box office (overseas collections were around ₹600 crore), a notable feat considering that multi-starrers with big budgets have usually dominated these numbers. That's what makes 2025 different, with capital and creative energy being allocated much more strategically.

Deshpande says *Dhurandhar*

was right on timing, especially considering the heightened sense of nationalism among audiences. “There was rage after Operation Sindoor. It's not only about jingoism,” she says. The film earned ₹890.80 crore till January 27. It also grossed ₹293.50 crore overseas. Yet, not all films tapping into nationalistic or historical themes resonated with audiences in 2025. *Emergency*, a politically charged biographical drama, generated a lot of anticipation but failed to turn that interest into ticket sales. It earned only a small portion of its modest budget and received criticism for uneven storytelling and unclear narrative. *Kesari Chapter 2*, despite its large cast and historical backdrop, also fell short of expectations. Its elevated production costs, combined with a shift toward a niche courtroom-drama approach, failed to attract a broad audience, leaving the film struggling to recover its investment. It ended its run with collections lower than its budget.

In contrast, *Dhurandhar* thrived thanks to strong execution, timely release, and a wider audience connection. This showed that having a theme isn't

NEW YEAR, NEW LOOK

1 Experts say putting the right actors in phenomenal stories directed by the right captain can do wonders

2 Bollywood's cost structure has long been unstable due to high star fees, limiting success

3 Experts now say that money should not be spent on the stars. Instead, it should go into the story, to put together a great narrative

4 Audiences are now more aware and discerning. They expect new stories every time

5 Old formulas have become outdated, and new leaner models, driven by content, have started emerging